



Photographed by: Manas Parekh

MOVING shooters

Camcorders are cheaper than ever and with holidays around the corner you don't want to be left without one. We look at a selection across all price ranges.

Michael Browne

April and May — the months of summer are characterised by unbearable heat and, of course, summer holidays for children and icy cold drinks. Most people are busy planning vacations to cooler climes at this part of the year. With kids on holiday from school, it makes an ideal time for parents to take their annual leave and plan vacations. Unfortunately, our busy work schedules almost always leave us with too little vacation time and there's almost too much to do once we're back, so more often than not, the vacation is forgotten almost as soon as it's over. It's for preserving such fun memories that camcorders were invented.

Whatever the occasion, nothing preserves memories like a well-shot video of the whole scene; from the build-up to the main event and beyond. A camcorder is the best way to ensure that your memories of the years gone by remain fresh, and reliving the fun moments is but a matter of slipping the correct disk into your DVD player.

With digital cameras shooting movie clips at up to 720p resolutions, we thought camcorders were largely meant to go the way of the dodo. After all, why pay Rs.

50,000 for a camcorder when you can buy a digital camera for Rs. 15,000 and record videos that are 80 per cent as good as some of the best camcorders around? Well, here's where camcorders, as a product category get their retort. They've become a whole lot cheaper and many camcorders are now available for well below the Rs. 20,000 mark. We found that there were a number of decent models in the market priced around the Rs. 17,000 to Rs. 20,000 price range.

Obviously, these are the more basic models available and typically use MiniDVD as their storage medium. Another emerging trend is the use of flash memory as storage. Thanks to the crash in flash prices, due to which USB drives have become dirt cheap, even camcorders that utilise the same flash memory to store captured video have become much cheaper. Owing to lower prices, the density of flash modules has also expanded and whereas last year we saw up to 8 GB of flash memory on a camcorder, this year we're seeing 32-GB models emerge. Soon, 64-GB models will make a splash as flash prices continue to fall.

The ultra common MiniDVD and DV tape camcorders also seem to be losing popularity. This was bound to happen,

and is a trend we anticipated some time back. Why pay extra for removable media and have the hassles of extra moving parts with cassette trays and such, when hard drives and flash can handle twenty times the storage? Also, flash and hard drives are both more reliable and faster. Perhaps the biggest reason for the traditional storage media (MiniDVD and DV tape) gradually becoming obsolete is the emergence of cheaper, HD camcorders. As we know, HD videos take a lot of space and with one MiniDVD offering a paltry 288 MB — which is only enough for around 2-3 minutes of shooting — no wonder manufacturers are adopting hard drives and flash. HDD storage is also becoming cheaper — thanks to market-wide adoption of larger hard drives. Although the largest capacity we've seen on a camcorder is 80 GB, with 1.8-inch micro drives now scaling up to 250 GB, it's only a matter of time until camcorders with drives of 100+ GB make a splash.

Perhaps the biggest shocker for us was the pricing. We actually found HD camcorders priced at well below the Rs. 40,000 mark! And we're not talking about a paltry HD resolution of 480p. We're talking 1080i — yes! — 1920 x 1080 interlaced pixels, in a body that's half the size of many MiniDVD camcorders.